description of personal experiences and perceptions, and an account of the vicissitudes of life spanning six-and-a-half decades. I have endeavoured to be as objective, down-to-earth and truthful as possible, but have no pretensions to literary excellence. It is an account of a simple and straightforward soldier born without a silver spoon in his mouth, who reached the top without any godfather.

My gratitude to my immediate family – my parents, my wife, Rohini, and children, Vivek and Sonia – who had to face the challenges of life so often without me, and suffer the pangs of separation. My wife perhaps understood my compulsions, but I am not too sure if my children could always comprehend them. Perhaps now, when they read this, the culmination of a personal and intensely passionate endeavour of mine for the last few years, they will understand me better.